Westbrook Planning Board

~ Planning Board Meeting ~

Date: Tuesday, November 3, 2026
Time: 7:00 PM
Location: Westbrook High School (Room 114), 125 Stroudwater St. (Hybrid via Zoom)
Video: https://vimeo.com/1243054968
Agenda:
https://www.westbrookmaine.gov/DocumentCenter/View/6429/November-3-2026-Agenda
(one-page agenda only — no fuller item-worksheet packet was posted as of this writing)

Timestamps below are clickable [0:00]-style links — they jump straight to that moment in the video.

This summary highlights the meeting's key discussions and decisions, with direct quotes and timestamps for verification — it is not a substitute for watching the full meeting. *Summarization necessarily condenses and selects; for complete context, nuance, and anything not covered here, watch the full video at the link above. (Produced by: WestbrookCurrents.com)*

I. Roll Call

Roll Call & Minutes [00:14]

Discussion Summary

Vice Chair John Turcotte presided; Chair Larry McWilliams was absent (he'd flagged at the Oct. 6 meeting that this date falls on Election Day). Roll call: five of seven regular members — Turcotte, Kevin Price, Nancy Litrocapes, Jason Frazier, and Karen Axelson — answered present; Robin Tannenbaum was absent along with McWilliams. Both alternates, Oriana Farnham and Lucas Schrage, were also absent but weren't needed for quorum. The Oct. 6, 2026 minutes were adopted.

Key Decisions

✓ Quorum established; Oct. 6, 2026 minutes approved, 5–0.

Action Items

None.

Regular Business

22-000604 — Site Plan Approval Extension — 860 Spring Street, Boulos Asset Management [01:58]

The applicant is requesting a fourth extension of the approval granted on November 1, 2022, for a 15,240 sq. ft. building addition located at 860 Spring Street. The requested extension would extend the approval date by one year, through November 1, 2027. Tax Map 003, Lot 101A, Industrial Park District.

Discussion Summary

Jake of Sebago Technics, representing Boulos Asset Management, said the extension comes down to interest rates and the broader economy — no tenant has been found for the addition in three years, but the applicant is

hopeful construction can begin before the new deadline. Vice Chair Turcotte noted the board's informal practice ("you definitely get one, you probably get two… we're on the fourth") but raised no objection given the financial constraints described. No public comment, on the floor or via Zoom. All findings, conclusions, and conditions from the 2022 approval remain in effect.

Key Decisions

✓ Approved 5–0 by roll call.

Action Items

None.

New Business

26-000847 — Land Use Ordinance Amendment, § 335-7.1 Village Review Overlay Zone (VROZ) [05:34]

The proposed amendments include modifications to the Village Review Overlay Zone review process as part of a city-wide initiative to review the structure and procedures of City boards, committees, and commissions for consistency with legal requirements and local practices.

Discussion Summary

Director Rebecca Spitella (Planning & Code Enforcement) explained this continues a city-wide ordinance-modernization effort workshopped with the board last month. The standalone Village Review Overlay Zone (VROZ) advisory committee will be sunset; its design standards stay in the ordinance, but review of village-design applications moves into the Planning Board's own process, where it's recorded and more accessible to the public. Spitella said staff met with current and past VROZ members, who recommended a broader, separate look at updating the VROZ standards themselves — newer development often doesn't fit standards written for an earlier era — which will return to the board in a future meeting. The amendment also narrows when a demolition inside the Village Review district needs Planning Board approval, to structures listed in or eligible for the National Register of Historic Places, so a deteriorating garage or shed isn't swept in alongside buildings of real historic significance. One board member asked whether giving the Chair a role in the demolition-approval recommendation process, as drafted, exists anywhere else in city ordinance; Spitella confirmed it does not — this would be a new role for the Chair.

> *"One of the things that I find valuable about [VROZ] is that they're just specifically focused on… that very specific set of ordinances. And when we bring this into the Planning Board, we're dealing with things that are all over the number of zones in the city… I don't know that we'd have the same luxury to focus in that deeply… I know that there's at least one architect and [a] historic preservationist [on VROZ] and they volunteer their time… that's quite a gift to the community."*
>
> **— Nancy Litrocapes, Planning Board member [10:10]**

Spitella responded that the shift reflects the board's own increased architectural focus over time, and that village-review items will still get a dedicated presentation and conversation at the Planning Board table rather than being folded silently into a site plan review. Litrocapes acknowledged the explanation but maintained her view — "I still think that if there was an adjustment in those one or two meetings a year where [the] public could attend, I still find value in that committee" [12:44] — and no one else raised objections.

Key Decisions

✓ Recommended to City Council, 5–0 by roll call.

Action Items

None.

Workshop — Riverwalk North (26-000913)

[14:15] Site Plan, Shoreland Zone: an 8-foot-wide multimodal riverwalk extending from the pedestrian bridge near Bridge Street to Garfield Street, along the Presumpscot River's north bank. Tax Map 032 and 039, Lots 223 and 031, City Center District and Residential Growth Area 1. Workshop only — no vote.

Project overview

Craig Burgess (project consultant, on behalf of the City) said a conceptual plan for this stretch dates to 2015, but the project in front of the board is “vastly different.” Environmental work began in 2018; Acorn Engineering was engaged in 2025. The team has held three public meetings (two neighborhood meetings in August and October 2025, plus one in September 2026 tied to the Maine Department of Environmental Protection (DEP) review) and met with regulators including Maine Inland Fisheries and Wildlife, Maine DEP, and the U.S. Army Corps of Engineers. A Maine DEP individual Natural Resources Protection Act permit application was submitted in October 2026. The major site plan application is expected back before the board for review in January 2027, with construction documents developed through 2027, permit approvals hoped for by March 2027, the brownfield-eligible first phase complete by September 2028, and the remainder of the project finished by October 2029.

Funding

The City was awarded a $4 million U.S. Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) Brownfields cleanup grant in 2025, with a September 2028 sunset date that Robyn Saunders (City Project Manager) said is unlikely to be extended “given the current climate” at the federal EPA. The full $4 million is available for this project; a separate $300,000 in Westbrook Improvement Corporation (WIC) seed funding covers costs that aren't Brownfields-eligible. Based on an escalated version of the 2015 cost estimate (originally $5–7 million, for a smaller, unpermitted concept), Saunders put the likely full construction cost at roughly **$8 million**, with a firmer number expected from a newly retained cost estimator by the end of 2026.

Environmental conditions

Allie Druin (Credere Associates) said 2023 soil sampling found sporadic, marginal exceedances of polycyclic aromatic hydrocarbons and some metals above Maine DEP remedial action guidelines along the corridor — not a single hot spot, so the whole stretch is treated as similarly affected. Rather than excavating soil along the riverbank, the remedial approach is to prevent exposure through engineering controls: keeping people on the boardwalk above the soil, maintaining vegetation to limit erosion and disturbance, an operation-and-maintenance plan requiring ongoing inspection, and — for the long term — an environmental covenant that will run with the property, satisfying a Maine DEP “no action assurance” letter that protects the City from future liability for the existing contamination.

Design

The trail links Cornelia Warren Fields, Riverbank Park, and the forthcoming Saccarappa Park, combining an on-grade asphalt path with elevated boardwalk sections used to span steep slopes and wetlands with minimal disturbance. A “parklet” is planned at a wider section of the site outside both the river's 25-foot setback and delineated wetlands, meant to let people step off the boardwalk and experience the river directly. Three site areas will test invasive-species control methods (Japanese knotweed, multiflora rose, Norway maple) before the rest of the corridor is treated. Lighting, security/emergency call boxes, seating, guardrail height, screening from abutting yards, and trash management are all still being studied; the boardwalk's decking material

(balancing durability against cost — the existing South Riverwalk's wood is in poor shape) hasn't been chosen yet.

Discussion highlights (no vote — workshop item)

Vice Chair Turcotte asked why the trail doesn't continue to the pedestrian bridge itself; the team confirmed the alignment (bridge to Garfield Street, rather than a longer route) was already set by the City Council's August resolve on this project and wasn't being revisited tonight. He also confirmed the elevated boardwalk sits entirely above the 100-year floodplain (only the helical pier foundations extend below it), that the parcel is public land rather than a right-of-way and will likely carry the same dawn-to-dusk hours as the rest of the Riverwalk system, and suggested matching the lighting design to the South Riverwalk "since we'll be looking across at each other."

> *"I live in an area where… the belief [is] that if you don't put a trash bin there, people will carry out their trash. I can tell you it's not true. There's trash constantly around the bus stop and there's no trash bin."*

— Nancy Litrocapes, Planning Board member [48:58]

(Litrocapes was referring to a Metro bus stop on Mechanic Street that has had no trash bin for 16 years.) Litrocapes also asked how the $4 million EPA grant compares to the project's likely total cost (see Funding above), raised design continuity between the new North Riverwalk and the existing South Riverwalk since the rendering shown didn't match — the team explained the two banks have genuinely different site conditions (the river's "cut bank" geometry differs on the south side) but committed to shared wayfinding and interpretive signage, and possibly shared art installations, to tie the two halves together — and asked how much of the existing tree canopy and river view would be preserved, drawing a commitment from the team to keep the boardwalk pushed back from the river's high-water line, protect the shoreline's existing silver maples, and revegetate any disturbed area. On trash/amenities, the team said benches and receptacles, if added, would most likely be concentrated at the parklet and the trail's end points rather than along the narrow 8-foot boardwalk itself, which needs to stay clear for emergency/utility vehicle access — and acknowledged Litrocapes's point directly rather than disputing it: "Let's have a community conversation about it. Thank you."

Key Decisions

No vote — workshop item. The major site plan application is expected to return to the board for formal review in January 2027.

Action Items

None.

How this was made

This summary was produced from the meeting video (linked above, hosted on the City's Vimeo showcase). The audio was downloaded with Downie 4 and transcribed with speaker diarization using MacWhisper. Claude (Anthropic's AI) cross-checked names against the official Planning Board roster and this pipeline's prior Planning Board meetings, attributed speakers from context (self-identification, direct address, roll-call order, and consistency with previously-established recurring roles) rather than the raw diarization labels alone, and drafted this summary and the quoted excerpts. Quotes are lightly cleaned of filler words/false starts but not reworded. The agenda posted for this meeting was a single page with no attached item worksheets, and had not yet appeared on the City's own Agenda Center as of this writing; it was found instead via a direct City Document Center link. Review tier: Not reviewed.

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